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5 Things Every Expat Should Know Before Getting a Car in Singapore

Your quick starter guide from ExpatAutoAdviser

A quick starter guide from the ExpatAutoAdviser team — the five things worth knowing before you start looking at cars. Keep an eye on your inbox for more detailed guides and market updates.

1 The COE will shock you

A Certificate of Entitlement — essentially the right to own a car for 10 years — costs S$80,000-140,000 on top of the car itself. This is the single biggest cost component and it fluctuates every two weeks at auction.

2 Cars have a 10-year expiry date

Every car in Singapore runs on a 10-year COE clock. At year 10 you scrap it (and get a partial rebate), renew the COE, or sell. This means depreciation works completely differently to the UK.

3 Consider renting before buying

If your posting is 2-3 years, a car lease often makes more financial sense than buying. You avoid the COE gamble and the resale risk. Run the numbers before you commit.

4 Convert your UK licence early

UK licences convert directly under Singapore's Direct Issue List — no driving test required. Do it in your first month while everything else is chaotic. You'll need an appointment, a fee, and an eye test.

5 Get a real insurance quote first

Expat driver + minimal Singapore no-claims discount + expensive car = premium shock. Get a real written quote from at least two insurers before you sign anything at the showroom.

> Want the full breakdown? Visit ExpatAutoAdviser.com for detailed guides on COE, FRT, insurance, and more.

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